Policy & Strategy Lab

Workbook 4: Priorities, Hypotheses and Workplan

Participant	
Name	
Case (problem statement)	
Decision-making role and decision	
Pod	

How to use this workbook

Each worksheet applies one day's anchor tool to your own case. Complete it during the session and finish it in your independent time. Keep earlier versions: revision is credited, so record what changed and why in the feedback box at the end of each worksheet. Tag every substantive claim in your Analyst's Ledger as fact, inference, assumption or hypothesis.

Competencies practised in this workbook: B4, E1, E2, F1, F2, F3.

Gate 2. This workbook ends with Gate 2. Submit the revised worksheets listed on the final worksheet, with a revision note and an AI-use disclosure.

Using AI tools. You may use AI tools to suggest structures, rival explanations or improvements to your writing. You may not use AI output as evidence. Every fact, figure, citation and description of an institution must come from a source you have checked.

Worksheet 4.1: Pruning matrix

Day 8: Prioritising issues. Anchor tool: Pruning matrix: size of effect against ability to influence.

Purpose. Choose the two or three branches of your tree that deserve your limited time, and record why the rest are set aside.

In brief.

- You cannot analyse everything. Choose deliberately and write down why.
- Rate branches by size of effect and ability to influence.
- Prioritising issues now is different from prioritising interventions in Week 4.
- Check that pruning has not quietly removed a small group bearing a large harm.

Worked example: Madhyapur (a stylised city; figures are illustrative). Madhyapur: analyse first, collection mixing and processing capacity; keep, narrowed, household space and know-how; quick check, monitoring; prune to context, national recycling prices.

Instructions.

1. List the level-two branches of your issue tree.
2. Rate each for size of effect and ability to influence, with a reason.
3. Place them on the matrix.
4. Choose two or three to analyse; prune the rest with written reasons.
5. Check that you have not pruned a branch only because it affects a small or voiceless group.

Pruning matrix

Branch	Size of effect (and why)	Ability to influence (and why)	Decision: analyse, check, context or prune

Pruned branches

Branch	Reason for pruning	Evidence that would bring it back

A thinker for your case: Herbert Simon. Given limited time and attention, what is good enough to investigate, and what will you knowingly leave out?

My answer, in one sentence

Reflection.

1. Simon: what is good enough to investigate in your case, and what are you knowingly leaving out?
2. Which pruning decision are you least confident about?
3. Did the equity check change any decision?

My reflections

Quality checklist.

- ☐ Every branch is rated on both dimensions, with reasons.
- ☐ Two or three priorities are chosen.
- ☐ Every pruned branch has a reason.
- ☐ The equity check is done.

Hand in. Worksheet 4.1 by the start of Day 9.

Before the next session. For each priority branch, write the one or two questions that, if answered, would most change your recommendation. About 40 minutes.

Feedback and revision

Feedback received (peer or instructor)	What I changed, and why

Worksheet 4.2: Hypothesis register

Day 9: Hypotheses. Anchor tool: Hypothesis register.

Purpose. Turn your priority branches into hypotheses that evidence could prove wrong, each with a rival.

In brief.

- A hypothesis is a claim that evidence could show to be wrong.
- Write the disconfirming test before looking for support.
- Keep a rival for every hypothesis; several may be partly true.
- Test first what is important and uncertain.

Worked example: Madhyapur (a stylised city; figures are illustrative). Madhyapur H1: payment by weight leads crews to mix separated waste. Weakened if crews mix just as much under per-household or per-trip contracts. Rival: vehicles lack compartments whatever the payment. Discriminating evidence: cities with compartment vehicles but weight-based contracts.

Instructions.

1. Turn each priority branch into one or two testable hypotheses, three to five in all.
2. For each, write the evidence that would weaken it and where you might find it.
3. Name a rival explanation and the evidence that would distinguish the two.
4. Map your assumptions by importance and evidence; mark which to test first.
5. Rate your current confidence in each: low, medium or high.

Hypothesis register

#	Hypothesis	Evidence that would weaken it, and where	Rival explanation	Discriminating evidence	Confidence

Assumption map

Assumption	Importance (high or low)	Evidence (known or uncertain)	Test first?

Reflection.

1. Which hypothesis do you most want to be true? Why is that a warning sign?
2. Did a challenge in the battle change one of your hypotheses? How?
3. How does your register compare with your sealed answer?

My reflections

Quality checklist.

- ☐ Three to five falsifiable hypotheses.
- ☐ Disconfirming evidence for each.
- ☐ A rival for each priority hypothesis.
- ☐ Assumptions labelled separately.

Hand in. Worksheet 4.2 by the start of Day 10, for Gate 2.

Before the next session. For each hypothesis, find one published source that could test it, and check that it covers your place and period. About 45 minutes.

Feedback and revision

Feedback received (peer or instructor)	What I changed, and why

Worksheet 4.3: Workplan and evidence register

Day 10: The workplan. Anchor tool: Workplan matrix: hypothesis, question, analysis, source, deadline.

Purpose. Commit to the analyses that matter most, with sources and dates, and start the record of your evidence.

In brief.

- A workplan turns hypotheses into promises: question, analysis, source, date.
- Check level, period and access before you commit to a source.
- Name evidence gaps and say how you will handle them.
- Keep the evidence register as you go; it is assessed.

Worked example: Madhyapur (a stylised city; figures are illustrative). Madhyapur: H1 contract, compare cities with different payment terms using published contracts, audits and case studies, by Day 13; H3 processing, set capacity against waste generated using the city's waste plan, by Day 12.

Instructions.

1. Turn each priority hypothesis into a research question.
2. For each, name the analysis, the source and the day by which it will be done.
3. List your evidence gaps and how you will handle each.
4. Open your evidence register with at least three sources.
5. Submit Gate 2 with a revision note and AI disclosure.

Workplan matrix

Hypothesis	Research question	Analysis	Source	By (day)

Evidence gaps

Gap	Why it exists	How I will handle it

Evidence register: first entries

Citation	Type	Coverage	Reliability and reason	Supports or weakens which hypothesis

Citation	Type	Coverage	Reliability and reason	Supports or weakens which hypothesis

Revision note

What changed since Gate 1	Why

AI-use disclosure

Tool used	For what	How you checked the output

Reflection.

1. Which analysis would most change your recommendation if it came out the other way?
2. Which evidence gap worries you most?
3. What did Gate 1 feedback change in your plan?

My reflections

Quality checklist.

- ☐ Every priority hypothesis has a question, analysis, source and date.
- ☐ Gaps are named with a plan for each.
- ☐ At least three register entries.
- ☐ Revision note and AI disclosure are complete.

Hand in. Gate 2 (Worksheets 3.1, 3.2, 4.1, 4.2 and 4.3, revised) by the end of Day 10. Feedback returned by Day 12.

Before the next session. Rest, then start the first analysis in your workplan. About 30 minutes.

Feedback and revision

Feedback received (peer or instructor)	What I changed, and why